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5G NETWORKS: DEVELOPMENT OF A 5G CORE AND RADIO ACCESS NETWORK

PRE-DISSERTATION INFORMATION

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NOVA University Lisbon

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LISTINGS

LIST OF LISTINGS

ACRONYMS

COTS	Commercial Off-The-Shelf (<i>p. 3</i>)
eNodeB	Evolved Node B (<i>p. 3</i>)
EPC	Evolved Packet Core (<i>pp. 2–4, 7</i>)
RAN	Radio Access Network (<i>pp. 2–4, 11</i>)
SCTP	Stream Control Transmission Protocol (<i>p. 4</i>)
SDR	Software-Defined Radio (<i>pp. 3, 4, 11</i>)
UE	User Equipment (<i>p. 3</i>)

BIBLIOGRAPHY

- [1] *MongoDB Community Edition: Installation Guide for Linux*. URL: <https://www.mongodb.com/docs/manual/administration/install-community/?operating-system=linux&linux-distribution=ubuntu&linux-package=default&search-linux=with-search-linux> (cit. on p. 8).
- [2] *Open5GS Guide: Quick Start*. URL: <https://open5gs.org/open5gs/docs/guide/01-quickstart/> (cit. on p. 7).

4G NETWORK SETUP

Before developing the 5G network testbed, a 4G network was first established to serve as a performance baseline and a proof-of-concept for all hardware and software components. The 4G network setup was essential for several reasons:

1. Validating that the chosen hardware and software stack functioned reliably
2. Establishing a known and well-documented reference point for network behavior
3. Identifying potential deployment hurdles before scaling to 5G complexity

This appendix documents the complete 4G testbed architecture, deployment procedures, and validation results.

The network stack consists of two dedicated machines running the backbone infrastructure: one running Open5GS for the Evolved Packet Core (EPC), while the other runs srsRAN 4G for the Radio Access Network (RAN). Readers can use this section as a guide for replicating the network, and as a foundation for understanding the experimental setup that enabled the 5G network development described in the main thesis.

This section will provide a comprehensive guide on how the 4G network was established, including a description of the equipment used for the setup and the software chosen for the network stack, the necessary setup steps and specific configurations applied to optimize performance, and the testing methodologies employed to validate the network's functionality and performance.

As an effort to make the network as reproducible as possible, the setup process will be detailed step-by-step, starting from the initial hardware assembly to the final testing phase. This will include instructions on how to connect the various components, configure the network settings, and troubleshoot common issues that may arise during the setup process.

.1 System Architecture Overview

The 4G testbed is a self-contained LTE system comprising three main functional domains:

- **RAN:** Handles air-interface communication using srsRAN Evolved Node B (eNodeB) software running on a dedicated machine, along with a Nuand BladeRF Software-Defined Radio (SDR) and appropriate antennas for signal transmission and reception
- **EPC:** Implements the core network functions using Open5GS software running on a separate machine, providing essential services such as authentication, user management, and data routing to the internet
- **User Equipment (UE):** Physical Commercial Off-The-Shelf (COTS) device configured to connect to the RAN and access the services provided by the EPC

Figure .1 presents the logical architecture.

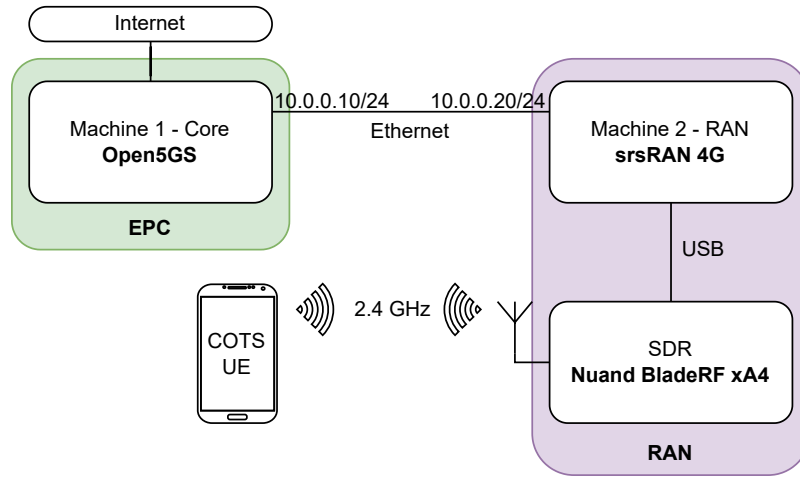


Figure .1: Logical architecture of the 4G network, illustrating the interactions between the RAN, EPC, and UE components.

.2 Hardware Components

The hardware used for the 4G network setup is composed of two identical machines, a Software-Defined Radio and antennas.

The computers running the 4G network are DELL Optiplex Micro 7020, with the following specifications:

Component	Machine 1	Machine 2
CPU	Intel Core i7-14700T	Intel Core i7-14700T
RAM	16 GB DDR5	16 GB DDR5
Operating System	Ubuntu 22.04 LTS	Ubuntu 22.04 LTS
Storage	512 GB SSD	512 GB SSD

Table .2: Specifications of the machines used for the 4G network setup.

Data flows between the machines via a dedicated Ethernet backhaul network, composed of the two computers. The RAN on Machine 2 establishes a connection to the EPC on Machine 1 using Stream Control Transmission Protocol (SCTP).

The radio interface of the 4G network is implemented using a Nuand BladeRF xA4 SDR. This device connects the Machine 2 to provide the necessary radio capabilities for the RAN. In practical terms, the host machine executes the signal processing and network stack components, whereas the BladeRF xA4 manages the actual radio I/O. This separation of responsibilities improves flexibility, simplifies experimentation, and makes the overall testbed easier to implement and adapt to different deployment scenarios.

Below, in Figure .2, shows the physical setup of the 4G network, including the two machines, the SDR, and the antennas. The photograph illustrates how the components are arranged in the lab environment, providing a visual reference for replicating the setup.



Figure .2: Photograph of the 4G network setup, showing the two machines, connected by an ethernet cable, the Nuand BladeRF xA4 SDR, and the antennas used for the radio interface.

.3 Software Components

.4 Connection between the machines

Before starting the setup, it is essential to first establish a connection between the two machines which will host the 4G network components. This connection is crucial as it enables the exchange of control and user data between the EPC and the RAN. The machines are connected via a ethernet cable, and the necessary network configurations are applied to ensure proper communication (.3).

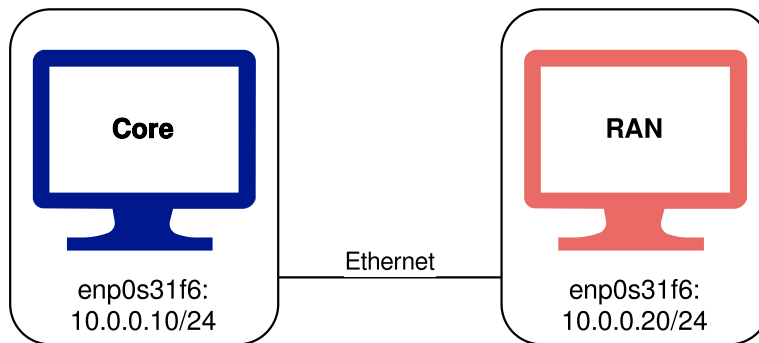


Figure .3: Diagram illustrating the connection between the two machines in the 4G network setup.

The steps to enable this connection are similar on both machines, differing only in the specific IP addresses assigned to each machine.

Connect both machines with an Ethernet cable and check the available network interfaces using the following command:

```
ip a
```

The output shows the available network interfaces, including the Ethernet interface (in this case enp0s31f6) ([4](#)).

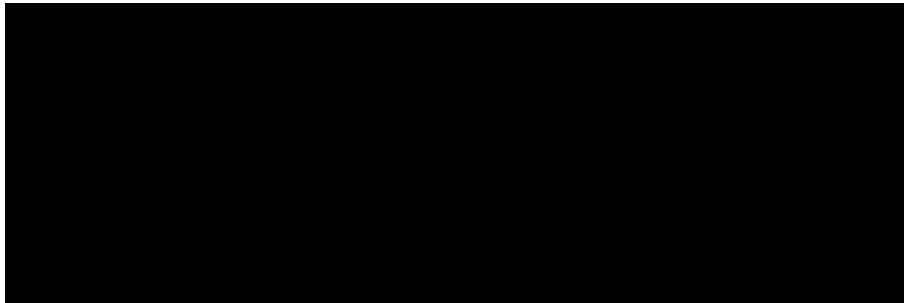


Figure .4: Output of the 'ip a' command, showing the available network interfaces, including the Ethernet interface (enp0s31f6).

Enable the Ethernet interface (if disabled) and assign a static IP address to it.

```
sudo ip link set enp0s31f6 up  
sudo ip addr add 10.0.0.10/24 dev enp0s31f6
```

Core: 10.0.0.10/24

RAN: 10.0.0.20/24

To make the connection persistent across reboots, the network configuration needs to be added to the Netplan configuration file. This file may have a different name from the one in this example. Open the Netplan configuration file on `/etc/netplan/01-netcfg.yaml` using a text editor and add the following configuration to assign a static IP address to the Ethernet interface:

```
# Let NetworkManager manage all devices on this system
network:
  version: 2
  renderer: NetworkManager
  ethernet:
    enp0s31f6:
      dhcp4: false
      addresses:
        - 10.0.0.10/24
```

After saving the changes, apply the new network configuration using the following command:

```
sudo netplan apply
```

Finally, verify that the machines can communicate with each other by pinging the assigned IP addresses. From Machine 1:

```
ping 10.0.0.20
```

The output should show successful ping responses, indicating that the machines are connected and can communicate with each other (.5).

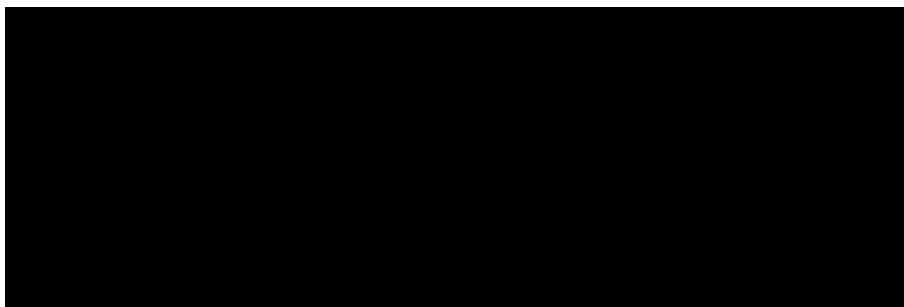


Figure .5: Output of the ping command, showing successful responses between the two machines, indicating that they are connected and can communicate with each other.

Having established a successful connection between the two machines, the next step is to proceed with the installation and configuration of the software components necessary for the 4G network setup.

.5 Software Setup

.5.1 Open5GS

This section provides a step-by-step guide for installing and configuring Open5GS. The installation process comprises of the following steps:

1. Installing MongoDB.
2. Adding the Open5GS repository and installing Open5GS packages.
3. Installing the WebUI for Open5GS.
4. Configuring Open5GS components (MME, HSS, SGW, PGW) according to the network requirements.

The necessary steps and more information about the project and installation steps can be found in the official Open5GS documentation [2]. Unless otherwise specified, all steps should be executed on the machine designated to run the EPC (Machine 1 in our setup).

.5.1.1 Installing MongoDB

Open5GS depends on MongoDB as its database backend, where it stores subscriber information, network configurations, and operational data. Therefore, the first step in setting up Open5GS is to install MongoDB:

```
sudo apt update
sudo apt install gnupg curl -y
curl -fsSL https://pgp.mongodb.com/server-8.0.asc | \
  sudo gpg -o /usr/share/keyrings/mongodb-server-8.0.gpg --dearmor

echo "deb [ arch=amd64,arm64 signed-by=/usr/share/keyrings/\
  mongodb-server-8.0.gpg ] https://repo.mongodb.com/apt/ubuntu \
  jammy/mongodb-enterprise/8.2 multiverse" | sudo tee \
  /etc/apt/sources.list.d/mongodb-enterprise-8.2.list

sudo apt update
sudo apt install -y mongodb-org
```

After executing the above commands, MongoDB will be installed on the machine. You can verify the installation by checking the MongoDB service status:

```
sudo systemctl status mongod
```

In which the output should indicate that the MongoDB service is active and running:

```
core@core:~$ sudo systemctl status mongod
● mongod.service - MongoDB Database Server
   Loaded: loaded (/lib/systemd/system/mongod.service; enabled; vendor preset: enabled)
   Active: active (running) since Tue 2026-04-21 17:41:12 WEST; 1 week 3 days ago
     Docs: https://docs.mongodb.org/manual
```

Figure .6: Output of the command to check MongoDB service status, showing that the service is active and running.

To ensure MongoDB starts automatically on system boot, you can enable the service with the following command:

```
sudo systemctl enable mongod
```

For more detailed instructions and troubleshooting guidance, refer to the official MongoDB installation documentation [1].

.5.1.2 Adding Open5GS Repository and Installing Open5GS Packages

After installing MongoDB, the next step is to add the Open5GS repository to the system and install the necessary Open5GS packages. This can be done by executing the following commands:

```
sudo add-apt-repository ppa:open5gs/latest
sudo apt update
sudo apt install open5gs
```

This will install the Open5GS packages, including the core network functions such as MME, HSS, SGW, and PGW. After the installation is complete, you can verify that the Open5GS services are running correctly by checking their status:

```
sudo systemctl status open5gs-*
```

.5.1.3 Installing WebUI for Open5GS

Open5GS provides a WebUI for easier management of subscriber information, network configurations, and monitoring. The interface depends on Node.js, which needs to be installed first (on most Ubuntu builds, Node.js comes already pre-installed). To install Node.js, you can use the following commands:


```

sudo apt update
sudo apt install -y ca-certificates curl gnupg
sudo mkdir -p /etc/apt/keyrings
curl -fsSL https://deb.nodesource.com/gpgkey/nodesource-repo.gpg.key |
sudo gpg --dearmor -o /etc/apt/keyrings/nodesource.gpg

NODE_MAJOR=20
echo "deb [signed-by=/etc/apt/keyrings/nodesource.gpg]
https://deb.nodesource.com/node_$NODE_MAJOR.x nodistro main" |
sudo tee /etc/apt/sources.list.d/nodesource.list

sudo apt update
sudo apt install nodejs -y

```

After installing Node.js, you can proceed to install the Open5GS WebUI by running the following command:

```

curl -fsSL https://open5gs.org/open5gs/assets/webui/install |
sudo -E bash -

```

You can access the WebUI by navigating to 'http://localhost:9999' in your web browser. The default login credentials are:

- Username: admin
- Password: 1423

.5.1.4 Configuring Open5GS Components

After installing Open5GS and the WebUI, the next step is to configure the core network components (MME, HSS, SGW, PGW) according to the network requirements and adhering to the legal regulations. In Open5GS, the configuration files for these components are located in the `/etc/open5gs/` directory, with each component having its own file.

First modify the MME configuration file, on `/etc/open5gs/mme.yaml`, to set the PLMN ID, TAC and IP address to attach the MME. Unless issued one by the national state regulator, use the international test PLMN ID (001/01), which is the one used in this configuration.

```

--- a/configs/open5gs/mme.yaml.in
+++ b/configs/open5gs/mme.yaml.in
@@ -10,7 +10,7 @@ mme:
    freeDiameter: @sysconfdir@/freeDiameter/mme.conf
    slap:

```

```
server:
-   - address: 127.0.0.2
+   - address: 10.0.0.10
gtpc:
server:
-   - address: 127.0.0.2
@@ -25,14 +25,14 @@ mme:
port: 9090
gummei:
plmn_id:
-   mcc: 999
-   mnc: 70
+   mcc: 001
+   mnc: 01
mme_gid: 2
mme_code: 1
tai:
plmn_id:
-   mcc: 999
-   mnc: 70
+   mcc: 001
+   mnc: 01
tac: 1
security:
integrity_order : [ EIA2, EIA1, EIA0 ]
```

Modify the SGWU configuration file, on `/etc/open5gs/sgwu.yaml` , to set the GTP-U IP address.

```
--- a/configs/open5gs/sgwu.yaml.in
+++ b/configs/open5gs/sgwu.yaml.in
@@ -15,7 +15,7 @@ sgwu:
#           - address: 127.0.0.3
```

```
gtpu:
server:
-   - address: 127.0.0.6
+   - address: 10.0.0.10
```

After modifying the configuration files, restart the Open5GS daemons to apply the changes:

```
sudo systemctl restart open5gs-mmed
sudo systemctl restart open5gs-sgwud
```

Having completed the configuration of the Core components, the next step is to proceed with the installation and configuration of the RAN components, which will be covered in the next section.

.5.2 SDR Configuration

Before proceeding with the installation of srsRAN 4G, it is necessary to first configure the Nuand BladeRF xA4 SDR and install the necessary drivers to bridge the connection between the software and the hardware. This procedure consists of the following steps:

1. Setting up the Nuand drivers and firmware for the BladeRF xA4.
2. Installing SoapySDR, which provides a common interface for SDR devices.

.5.2.1 Setting up the Nuand drivers and firmware for the BladeRF xA4

Nuand provides official Ubuntu package repositories (PPAs) that simplify the installation of the BladeRF software in Ubuntu systems. Through these repositories, users can quickly install both the required host tools and libraries using the standard package manager, and the necessary firmware for the FPGA, without needing to build everything manually from source. To enable the PPA:

```
sudo add-apt-repository ppa:nuandllc/bladerf
sudo apt update
```

After enabling the PPA, you can install the BladeRF software and firmware using the following command:

```
sudo apt install bladerf
sudo apt install bladerf-fpga-hostedx40
```

To bridge the connection between the BladeRF xA4 and the RAN, SoapySDR will be used, which will be covered in the next section ([.5.2.2](#)). For this to work, the header files for the BladeRF drivers need to be installed:

```
sudo apt install libbladerf-dev
```

.5.2.2 SoapySDR

.5.3 srsRAN 4G

.6 Running the network